A Commentary on the Praise of the Three Bodies

Kāyatrayastotranāmasyavivaraṇa · Toh 1124 · Derge Tengyur

ལ་ཆགས་མུ་ལ་བས་རྣོ་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའི་རིམ་པར་འགྲེལ་པ

This is A Commentary on the Praise of the Three Bodies, known in Sanskrit as the Kāyatrayastotranāmasyavivaraṇa and in Tibetan as Kusum la Töpa Zhé Jawé Nampar Drelpa. It is a phrase-by-phrase explanation of Nāgārjuna's short hymn, the Praise of the Three Bodies, which pays homage in turn to the three bodies of a buddha: the Dharma body, beyond one and many and beyond existence and nonexistence; the enjoyment body, which teaches the bodhisattvas of the ten grounds; and the emanation body, which appears in many forms to ripen beings. After setting out the subject matter, purpose, and connection of the work, the commentary glosses each line of the verses, recounts how the Buddha awakened in Akaniṣṭha and then displayed the deeds of his final life, and closes with a dedication of merit toward leading all beings onto the path of awakening. It is Toh 1124 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the Praises (stotra) section, and it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Śraddhākaravarman and the Tibetan translator Rinchen Zangpo.

In the language of India: kāyatrayastotranāmasya vivaranāma. In the language of Tibet: A Commentary on the Text Called Praise of the Three Bodies.

Homage to the noble Mañjuśrī in youthful form.

The praise of the three bodies of the Great Being
That Nāgārjuna composed,
Urged on by the requests of others,
I shall analyze just as it was set out.

Here I shall state the subject matter expressed by the three verses beginning "Neither one nor many," together with the purpose, the connection, and the purpose of the purpose. For those who examine before they act do not take up what lacks a subject matter, a purpose, and a connection. Therefore the subject matter is explained in order to engage the mindfulness of those who are utterly bewildered about this, wondering, "What is going to be explained here?" The purpose is taught so that those who suppose the explanation to be of no benefit will be sure to engage with it. The connection is explained in order to dispel the suspicion that there is no means; for otherwise, how could anyone engage with what has no means?

Now, here the three bodies are the subject matter. The explanation of their own essential nature is the purpose, for these verses were composed in order to explain their own essential nature. Therefore the connection is this: the purpose and the verses are related in the character of expression and what is expressed; or as words and that which possesses the words; or in the character of a means and what arises from the means; or in the character of what accomplishes and what is to be accomplished; or in the character of action and agent. Then, to bring the aim and the activity of the three bodies to completion oneself, endowed with the diligence of striving and exertion: this should be understood as the purpose of the purpose. This, for the moment, is the general meaning.

Now I shall state the meaning of the individual parts. In the passage beginning "Neither one nor many," "one and many" means "one" and "many." "One" means having no second, and "many" means multiplicity. The sense is: "I pay homage to that Dharma body (dharmakāya) which has become neither one nor many." If one asks why it is neither one nor many, it is for this reason: since it is stated, "It is unborn from the very beginning," what is unborn from the very outset cannot be put into the condition of one or many. Like space, its essential nature is free of all delimitation. All phenomena, moreover, arise from suchness. Therefore, whatever comes to arise from something, nothing is seen by which it would turn into forms of every kind: from the seed of rice and the like comes the fruit of rice. In the same way, whatever arises from emptiness becomes neither permanent nor annihilated, for all the Victors (the buddhas), who are free of every conceptual thought without exception, see it as empty and like an illusion.

Further, to qualify it more specifically, the verse says, "the basis of the great excellence of benefit for self and others." "Self and others" means oneself and others. "Having become the basis of the excellence of benefit for them" means having become the basis of the great excellence characterized by elevated states and definitive goodness. Since the expanse of reality (dharmadhātu) has been explained as emptiness, a nature free of one and many and without beginning or end, how can it be the basis of the great excellence of benefit for self and others? There is no fault. For just as, through the power of the habitual tendencies of ignorance, it abides as the container world and its inhabitants, so it is the basis of the great excellence of benefit for self and others, like the cognitions of dreams and so forth. If one asks about the habitual tendencies of ignorance and the expanse of reality: even that nature of the expanse of

reality, which is without beginning or end, comes to be the habitual tendencies of ignorance, just as a thing is perfumed by musk and the like. Such is the very nature (dharmatā) of things. Therefore it is the basis of the excellence of benefit for self and others.

Moreover, when, by meeting a virtuous spiritual friend and finding the excellent path, the adventitious habitual tendencies of ignorance are put far away and it becomes completely pure, that is like gold and copper freed from their stains. In this there is the taking up of good qualities and the casting off of faults. If one asks why that is: it comes down to nothing more than realizing the true meaning. Therefore it is said:

In this there is nothing whatsoever to be removed,
And nothing at all to be measured.
One looks truly at the true itself;
Seeing the true, one is liberated.

This means that whatever is possessed of conditions would necessarily be thoroughly afflicted, but the unborn is not seen to arise. Nor does anything whatsoever arise from what has arisen and ceased: nirvāṇa is like a lamp.

Further, to qualify it more specifically, the verse says, "Neither entity nor nonentity." An entity is what exists as form. Its having become nonexistent is a nonentity. Since it is excluded from both, the verse says, "Neither nonentity nor existing entity"; that is, it has passed beyond existence, nonexistence, and the middle. For that very reason it is "of one taste like space." "Like space" means this: whatever, like space, has come to be of one taste, with an intrinsic nature of equality, is called "of one taste like space." For that very reason it is "of an intrinsic nature hard to realize": it lies beyond any search among entity, nonentity, both, or something else. Therefore it is "unsullied": it is free of the stains of faults such as attachment. For that very reason it is "changeless": it does not shift from its own essential nature. "Peaceful" means that all afflictions have been pacified. "Unequaled" means that it has no match. "Equal" means that it is equally the ground of all phenomena. "All-pervading" means that it has gone everywhere. "Free of elaboration" means that it is free of all conceptual elaborations.

Another qualification is "personally self-cognized": it is cognized by sentient beings, each individually by themselves, like a young girl asking about bliss. "Without example" means that it has passed beyond every example. As it is also said:

Nothing whatsoever is comparable;
What is there even within the range of words?
Anything even slightly near or far
Does not exist at all.
The Guide has become one without equal:
What could be weighed as an example for him?
Free of any ground that would give an opening,
Unequaled one, to you I pay homage.

To such a Dharma body, that is, the body of Dharma, I pay homage. If one asks how, and to whom, the meaning is: "With body and mind I pay homage to the Victors, whose minds are empowered through their comprehension of every knowable thing without exception."

"Its own splendor" bears the defining characteristic of great lordship over all the three realms. If one asks what distinguishes it: it is "beyond the world," that is, it has crossed over the world. "Inconceivable" means that it is far removed from the domain of the mind. "The fruit of a hundred good deeds" means that it is born from the perfections, such as generosity, accumulated over a long time. If one asks, "Whose?": "of the wise," that is, of Maitreya, Amoghadarśin, Sarvāpāyañjaha, Sarvaśokatamonirghātamati, and others. If one asks, "For what reason?": "to bring forth joy," that is, as a cause of their great delight. "The assembly" is the host of bodhisattvas; it is in their midst. "Various" means of many kinds. It is said to "display extensively": taking into account the particular dispositions of sentient beings of various inclinations, it explains in many distinct ways.

"The one who constantly makes the vast voice of the sacred Dharma radiate throughout all the worlds" refers to the exceedingly vast speech of the sacred Dharma. It is "vast" because it enters everywhere. For that very reason, since it sends this forth without interruption, the one who comes to teach and proclaim the sacred Dharma, exceedingly abundant, vast, and so forth, is so described. "Buddha" means one who has found and fully understood the reality of phenomena just as it is. "Enjoyment body" (saṃbhogakāya) means the body of complete enjoyment: it takes its enjoyment by teaching the Dharma in its many aspects, and so forth, to the bodhisattvas who are lords of the ten grounds. Therefore, as a further qualification, the verse says, "which abides in the great kingdom of the Dharma." Since it is both a kingdom of the Dharma and great, it is "the great kingdom of the Dharma," that is, sovereignty over all the three realms. The body that abides in it is what is so

described.

Having thus set forth with two verses the own nature of both of the two bodies, in order to show the nature of the emanation body (nirmāṇakāya), the verse says, "Which, to ripen sentient beings, appears at certain times like a blazing fire," and so on. "Sentient beings" are living creatures. If one asks, "For what reason?": "to ripen them," that is, for the sake of their full maturation. It is that which at certain times appears blazing all around, like fire, like Agni, the devourer of oblations, and which, being endowed with light, appears brilliantly ablaze. If one asks in what places it appears, the reply is: "in perfect awakening," that is, at awakening itself. "The wheel of Dharma" is at Vārāṇasī, in the Deer Park at Ṛṣivadana. "And which appears in utter peace" refers to its display of the great parinirvāṇa in the grove of twin śāla trees in the vicinity of the Mallas. If one asks what distinguishes it: "through various skillful means and methods," that is, it displays itself in many different forms, such as a buddha, a pratyekabuddha, a śrāvaka, a bodhisattva, Brahmā, Śakra (Indra), Maheśvara (Śiva), and so on. If one asks in what particular way: "engaging in many ways," that is, it conforms to the many kinds of diverse beings to be trained. If one asks what distinguishes it: "dispelling the fears of the three existences," that is, putting far away the ills, such as birth, of the sentient beings of the three existences, namely desire, form, and the formless, is dispelling fear.

Further, to qualify it more specifically, the verse says, "the emanation body of the Sages, of great benefit, which fills the ten directions." "Filling the ten directions" means pervading all ten directions. "Sages": because they possess the sagely mastery of body and speech, they are sages, that is, the buddhas, the Blessed Ones. "Of great benefit" means that it bestows, or brings about the attainment of, the fruits of elevated states and definitive goodness. "To such an emanation body I pay homage," said the master Nāgārjuna.

This shows the following. The holy bodhisattva Śvetaketu, who had himself brought the accumulations of merit and wisdom to completion and dwelt in the celestial palace of Tuṣita, the supreme abode, by the intrinsic nature of his mind and through the stages of having meditated on loving-kindness, compassion, joy, equanimity, and the four meditative concentrations, became a perfect buddha in Akaniṣṭha, the abode of great yoga, through the sequence of the five manifest awakenings. Then, in an emanation body, he went to where all the tathāgatas abide in their enjoyment bodies and to the summit of the vajra-jewel celestial palace atop great Mount Meru, and manifestly

emanated the four kinds of maṇḍala. Then, once again becoming one with the holy Śvetaketu, who dwelt in the supreme abode of Tuṣita, he fully displayed entering the womb, birth, appearing to sport amid his consorts, the going forth by night, the practice of austerities, going to the seat of awakening, subduing Māra, manifest awakening, and, from turning the wheel of Dharma up to the great parinirvāṇa, acting for the benefit of all beings without exception. The meaning is: "To that emanation body I pay homage with body, speech, and mind." It is for this very reason that it was said:

In the delightful abode of Akaniṣṭha,
Dwelling above the Pure Abodes,
The perfect Buddha awakened there;
The emanations awakened here.

Having thus shown the three bodies with three verses, further, because he wishes to make an aspiration, he says, "Constantly working solely for the benefit of sentient beings," and so on. "The benefit of sentient beings" means fully accomplishing the desired aims of living creatures. Therefore the one who constantly works solely for the benefit of beings is the one "constantly working solely for the benefit of sentient beings." This is to be construed with "by paying homage": "by paying homage to the one who works thus for the benefit of sentient beings." If one asks with what qualities it is endowed, the verse says, "arisen from immeasurable great merit and wisdom." "Great merit and wisdom" means being endowed with the six perfections. Their being accumulated without any limit is "immeasurable." "Arisen from immeasurable great merit and wisdom" means born from these.

If one asks who that is: it is the Sugatas (the buddhas). Since they have the quality of having gone beautifully, or of having gone never to turn back, they are Sugatas, the Well-Gone Ones. Or else, since they have brought their own aim to completion, they are Sugatas. "Their three bodies" are the three bodies called the Dharma body, the enjoyment body, and the emanation body. Therefore, if one asks what the distinctive qualities of these are, the verse says, "utterly beyond the paths of mind and words," meaning that they lie wholly beyond the mind's domain of things that can be apprehended. It is from bowing down and paying homage, with the faith of conviction, to what is of such a nature. "The virtue I have made, the seed of awakening": the seed of awakening means the awakening mind (bodhicitta). That is, it has been cultivated and accumulated. Hence, through whatever accumulation of merit comes from this, may I attain and actualize the three bodies, characterized as

Dharma, complete enjoyment, and emanation, and lead all beings, without exception and without remainder, onto the path of awakening. "The path of awakening" is the path to awakening, and the meaning is: "May I fully lead and establish them on that great path, the noble eightfold path."

This king of praises, the province of the learned of outstanding qualities,
Utterly flawless and vast, conceals a mass of essential meanings.
Here, by way of explanation, I have taken merely the tip of a leaf;
In this, the supremely learned who follow the meaning are the valid authority.

The commentary on the Praise of the Three Bodies composed by the master Nāgārjuna is complete.

It was newly translated and edited by the Indian preceptor Śraddhākaravarman and the Tibetan translator, the monk Rinchen Zangpo.

Translator's Notes

• In "'One' means having no second," the Tibetan reads gnyis ("two") where the gloss plainly requires gcig ("one"); the letters ca and nya are easily confused, and "one" is translated. The verse "In this there is nothing whatsoever to be removed" is the well-known verse also found in the Ratnagotravibhāga; its second line here reads gzhal ("to be measured") where the familiar form has gzhag ("to be added"), and it is translated as it stands. The sentence beginning "If one asks about the habitual tendencies of ignorance" has no closing question marker; it is read as an implied objection about how the beginningless expanse of reality can take on ignorance's tendencies. The commentary's second quotation of the root line differs in wording from the first ("existing entity" in place of "nonentity") and is read as denying both alternatives, as its context requires. The young girl asking about bliss is a traditional image for what can be known only by experiencing it oneself. In the quoted verse, "free of any ground that would give an opening" (skabs 'byed gzhi) is uncertain in sense; it may mean that nothing offers room for comparison.
• In the first sentence, dbang phyug chen po is taken in its general sense, "great lordship" over the three realms, not as the god Maheśvara, who is named later in the list of forms. The bodhisattva Sarvaśokatamonirghātamati appears here under a shortened Tibetan form of his name ("Intelligence That Utterly Destroys All Sorrow"). The gloss on "Sages" plays on the Tibetan thub pa, which renders muni and also means mastery or capability; the wordplay cannot be kept in English. The account of Śvetaketu's awakening in Akaniṣṭha through the five manifest awakenings and the emanation of four maṇḍalas atop Mount Meru follows the Yoga tantra narrative. The clause rendered "he went to where all the tathāgatas abide in their enjoyment bodies" could also be read as "together with all the tathāgatas, who abide in their enjoyment bodies."
• The three explanations of "Sugata" (gone beautifully, gone never to return, having completed one's own aim) are the traditional etymologies of the Sanskrit word. The last line of the closing verse is read as the commentator's modest deferral to the learned as the authority; it could also be read as "for the supremely learned who follow the meaning, this is authoritative." In the colophon, "composed by the master Nāgārjuna" may qualify the root praise rather than the commentary; the commentary itself names Nāgārjuna as the author of the praise it explains.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.